



Fiona Stanley Fremantle Hospitals Group

OFFICIAL

Policy and Procedure

Medication dispensing after hours by a Medical Prescriber: Mental Health

Reference #: FSFH-MENH-POL-0010

Scope

Site	Service/Department/Unit	Disciplines
Fremantle Hospital Fiona Stanley Hospital (Cockburn Health site only)	Mental Health Service	Medical, Pharmacy

1. Introduction

Patient safety is best maintained by the separation of prescribing and dispensing of medications. However, there may be occasions where medications are required to be dispensed by the prescriber where other avenues of supply by a dispensing pharmacist are not available.

When required it may be appropriate for prescribers to dispense a small supply of clinically urgent medication to patients after hours. This policy and procedure outlines the process for a doctor to dispense a limited supply of medication to a mental health patient upon discharge from a ward at Fremantle Hospital or Cockburn Health or on presentation to the Mental Health Crisis Centre at Fremantle Hospital.

2. Terminology

Dispense

'Dispense' in relation to a medicine means supply of the medicine in accordance with a prescription duly given by an authorised prescriber.

The container of the medicine must be labelled appropriately with the generic name, strength, form and quantity of the medicine, along with clear instructions on how to take the medicine, the patient's name, the prescriber's name, an address of the hospital at which it is dispensed and the date of dispensing.

Appendix K	Appendix K of the Poisons Standard (also known as the Standard for the Uniform Scheduling of Medicines and Poisons (SUSMP)), which defines drugs required to be labelled with a sedation warning or cautionary and advisory label number 1. The current version is available from the Therapeutic Goods Administration .
Schedule 4	Medications listed in Schedule 4 of the Poisons Standard (also known as the Standard for the Uniform Scheduling of Medicines and Poisons (SUSMP)).
Schedule 4 Restricted	Medications listed in “Risk based requirements for medicines handling” of the Medicines Handling Policy MP0139/20 which are subject to additional storage and recording requirements in addition to S4 requirements.
Schedule 8	Medications listed in Schedule 8 of the Poisons Standard (also known as the Standard for the Uniform Scheduling of Medicines and Poisons (SUSMP)).
Standard for the Uniform Scheduling of Medicines and Poisons (SUSMP)	The Poisons Standards is a Legislative Instrument and consists of decisions regarding the classification of medicines and poisons into Schedules.
State Medicines Formulary	List of medications permitted to be prescribed at FSFHG. Available on the SMHS Library and Information Hub page.
Pharmaceutical Benefits Scheme (PBS)	The PBS Schedule lists all of the medicines available to be dispensed to patients at a Government subsidised price. Available on the SMHS Library and Information Hub page.
Mental Health Crisis Centre (MHCC)	First point of contact and access to the mental health services offered at Fremantle Hospital, and is responsible for the assessment and management of patients who present to triage.
Pre-labelled blank dispensing bottle or box	Boxes and bottles with blank labels used to dispense medication into.
Imprest	Forward loan of pharmacy stock to a defined storage area
Notification & Clinical Summaries (NaCS)	Health application that allows users to complete a patient's discharge summary. Communicates electronically with the patients General Practitioner.
Best Practice	Medication Management and Support Program
Consumer medication Information (CMI)	Document containing written information on the safe and effective use of a medication and potential side effects. The Department of Health (DoH) Choice and Medication printable leaflets are recommended.

3. Policy

Medical Prescribers will only dispense medications outside of the Fremantle Hospital Pharmacy or Cockburn Health Pharmacy opening hours as follows:

Fremantle Hospital Pharmacy

- weekdays: 0800hrs to 1700hrs
- weekends and public holidays: 0830hrs to 1330hrs

Cockburn Health Pharmacy

- weekdays: 0830hrs to 1630hrs
- weekends and public holidays: all day

Prescribers may only dispense a limited supply of medication up until the next pharmacy working day (i.e. 24-72 hours supply).

- Only doctors and pharmacists are authorised to dispense medication in accordance with a prescription from an authorised prescriber.
- For after-hours dispensing, legal responsibility is taken by the doctor performing the dispensing.
- Prescribers may only dispense:
 - a limited supply up to the next pharmacy working day
 - to patients who are deemed unable to have a PBS prescription dispensed from a community pharmacy within an appropriate time frame of the medication being required; or
 - medications required urgently that are not available on the PBS; or
 - medications where non-compliance will affect the patient's mental health.
- Prescriptions for, and dispensing of, after-hours discharge medications must comply with:
 - Medicines and Poisons Act 2014
 - Medicines and Poisons Regulations 2016
 - Statewide Medicines Formulary
 - FSFHG Medication Administration policy and procedure
 - Western Australian Department of Health Mandatory Policies

4. Procedure

Refer to [Appendix 1](#) for a flowchart of the medical prescriber dispensing process.

4.1. Prescribing

- Whenever possible the preferred option for supply of medications is for the prescriber to provide the patient with a prescription to be filled at a community pharmacy or the Fremantle Hospital Outpatient Pharmacy the following working day.
- Medical practitioners working within FSFHG are able to provide patients with a South Metropolitan Area Health Service – Mental Health Voucher which can be used to subsidise the costs of medications for the patient. List of participating pharmacies is available [here](#).
- Where this is not suitable, a doctor may dispense a limited supply up to the next pharmacy working day of clinically urgent medication from an imprest supply into either a pre-labelled blank dispensing bottle or box. Refer to [Appendix 1: Medical Prescriber Dispensing Process](#)

4.2. Packaging

- Medications will NOT be:
 - Dispensed into an envelope
 - Combined with other medications into one box or bottle
- Pre-labelled blank boxes and bottles are provided by pharmacy for medications dispensed from an imprest supply for MHCC outpatients or patients discharged from a mental health ward after hours.
- The pre-labelled blank boxes and bottles are available in the W4.1 Imprest Room at Fremantle Hospital or the Ward 1 Medication Room at Cockburn Health.
- Documentation of supply in Schedule 8 and Schedule 4 Restricted registers will be completed as per Poisons Regulations, DoH policy and according to site Medication Administration policy and procedure.

4.3. Labelling

- Pre-labelled boxes or bottles must always be used by a medical prescriber to dispense medication.
- The prescriber dispensing the medication must hand write on the blank label:
 - the generic medication name, strength, form and quantity dispensed
 - clear instructions for use
 - the patient's name, prescriber's name and the date and time of dispensing.

- The address of the hospital it is being dispensed at will be pre-printed onto the label.
- All medications listed in Appendix K provided by the TGA are legally required to have a cautionary and advisory label number 1 attached to the final packaging. Refer to Figure 1.
- The current edition from the TGA must be referred to for all medications requiring cautionary and advisory label number 1.
- As the boxes and bottles are pre-labelled, all the medications issued from the mental health service will be labelled with a cautionary and advisory label number 1 as predominantly all mental health medications require this labelling. Refer to Figure 2.

Figure 1. Cautionary and Advisory Label Number 1

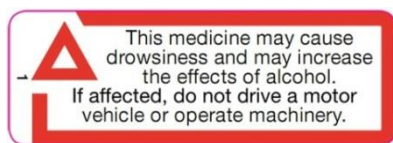
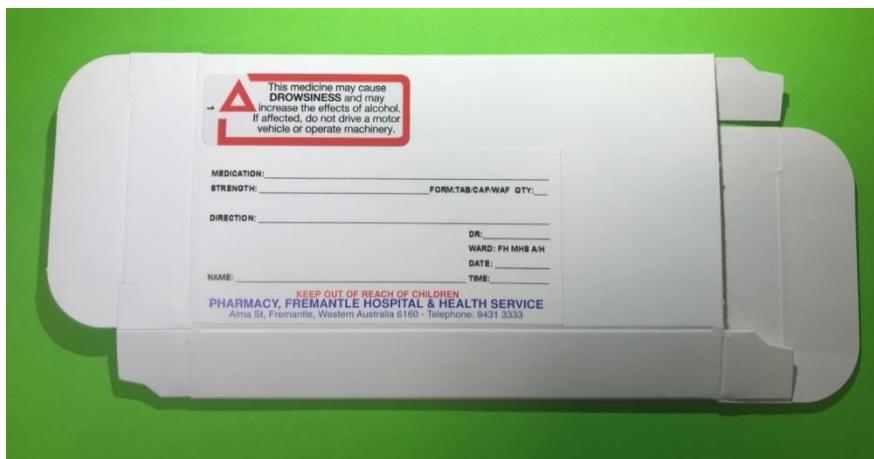


Figure 2. Pre-labelled box



4.4. Dispensing to patient

- The patient will be identified using 3 points of identification.
- Written information must be provided to the patient in addition to a comprehensive explanation of the advantages and potential side effects associated with medications as well as compliance and discontinuation issues.
- Choice and Medication mental health specific CMIs can be accessed via the SMHS library or DoH [Choice and Medication Printable Leaflets](#)

- Post-dispensing, the prescription will be filed in the after-hours dispensing script box in the Ward W4.1 Imprest room in W Block for Fremantle Hospital or the Pharmacist Tray in the Ward 1 Medication Room for Cockburn Health.
- A copy of the prescription marked 'copy' will be sent for scanning into the digital medical record.

5.Compliance/Performance Monitoring

- Compliance against this policy will be evaluated by the Mental Health Service Pharmacist by:
 - Annual review of prescriptions and incident reports

6.Related Policy Documents

- DOH:
 - [Medicines Handling Policy MP 139/20](#)
 - [Mental Health Policy Framework](#)
- FSFHG
 - Prescribing and medication authorisation policy and procedure
 - Medication Administration policy and procedure
 - Patient Identification policy and procedure
 - High Risk Medications policy

7.Related Standards

- NQSHS Standards:
 - Clinical Governance
 - Medication Safety
 - Communicating for Safety

8. Bibliography

Medicine and Poisons Act 2014

[Medicines and Poisons Act 2014 00-d0-05.docx \(legislation.wa.gov.au\)](#)

Medicines and Poisons Regulations 2016

[Medicines and Poisons Regulations 2016 - \[00-g0-00\].pdf \(legislation.wa.gov.au\)](#)

Pharmaceutical Benefits Scheme

<http://www.pbs.gov.au/pbs/home>

9. Authorisation

EXECUTIVE SPONSOR: Servicer Director, Service 5					
Version	Date Issued	Compiled/Revised By	Committee/Consumer Group Consulted	Endorsed By	Revision due
1	07/2019	Senior Pharmacist	DTC	FSFHG Policy Committee	07/2022
2	07/2022	Senior Pharmacist	DTC	Service 5 Safety Quality and Risk Committee	09/2025
3	07/2024	FSH-CH MH Team Lead Pharmacist	DTC	Service 5 Safety Quality and Risk Committee	09/2025
4	11/2025	FH MH Team Lead Pharmacist	DTC	FSFH Mental Health Clinical Governance Sub-Committee	12/2028

10. Appendices

10.1. Appendix 1: Medical Prescriber Dispensing Process

